

Button Maker

WHAT'S IN THE KIT

- Button maker press
- Button components (shells, mylar, pin backs)



QUICK-START GUIDE

1. Design artwork in the button-circle template (paper or digital).
2. Cut out the circle, layer it with mylar in the press.
3. Press once to crimp, rotate, press again to finish.
4. Adult or trained student operates the press; everyone designs.

FULL LESSONS IN THIS GUIDE

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PRO TIP: Buttons make school events feel official — counselors love this one for kindness campaigns.

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LESSON · GRADES K-2

I'm-An-Expert Buttons

LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Students will communicate an idea within a small visual space
- Students will follow a multi-step production process
- Students will celebrate personal accomplishment publicly

MATERIALS

- Button maker (adult-operated) + button components
- Circle template sheets sized to the press
- Crayons, markers, scissors
- 'I'm an expert at...' brainstorm chart

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brainstorm together: everyone names something they can do ('count to 100', 'tie shoes').
2. Design in the circle template: big letters, bold drawing — model why edges get cut off.
3. Cut out circles (with help as needed).
4. Production line: each student watches THEIR button get pressed — adult presses.
5. Pin-on ceremony with a share circle: everyone states their expertise aloud.
6. Wear buttons for the day; other classes will ask, and re-telling is the point.

ACTIVITY

I'm-An-Expert Buttons — every student designs and wears proof of something they've mastered. Explaining their button to curious kids at recess is the confidence curriculum.

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LESSON · GRADES 3-5

Campaign Buttons

LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Students will distill an argument into a slogan and image
- Students will apply persuasion basics to a visual design
- Students will support a position with reasons

MATERIALS

- Button maker + components
- Campaign context: book characters, historical figures, or class election
- Real campaign button examples (images)
- Design template with slogan lines

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Examine real campaign buttons: what do 5 words and a face accomplish?
2. Students choose a candidate (character/figure) and list their three best qualities.
3. Slogan workshop: compress the argument into punchy button-sized text.
4. Design with hierarchy: name biggest, slogan readable, image supporting.
5. Press the buttons (adult or trained helper operates).
6. Campaign rally: 30-second stump speeches wearing the button.

ACTIVITY

Campaign Buttons — persuasion compressed to a 2-inch circle plus a stump speech. Distilling a character's case into five words is rigorous summarization wearing a costume.

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LESSON · GRADES 6-8

Cause Merch Design

LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Students will research a cause and define a target audience
- Students will design merchandise with consistent visual identity
- Students will plan a small awareness campaign

MATERIALS

- Button maker + components
- Cause research resources
- Brand board template: colors, message, audience
- Campaign plan sheet: where, who, how many

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Teams research and select causes with a local angle where possible.
2. Define the audience: who needs this message, and what would make them wear it?
3. Design a 3-button 'merch line' with consistent colors and message family.
4. Peer test: would your audience actually pin this on? Revise from feedback.
5. Produce a small run on the press.
6. Launch plan presentations: distribution, message goals, how they'd measure impact.

ACTIVITY

Cause Merch Design — a three-button branded line for a researched cause, tested against the brutal question: would anyone actually wear this? Social marketing in miniature.

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LESSON · GRADES 9-12

Club & Event Branding

LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Students will manage a production pipeline from design to distribution
- Students will calculate unit costs and set pricing
- Students will deliver a product for a real school client

MATERIALS

- Button maker + component inventory (counted)
- Real orders: clubs, events, fundraisers, spirit days
- Cost/pricing worksheet
- Order form and production log

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Land real orders: student council, clubs, or an upcoming school event.
2. Client intake: quantities, deadline, design requirements.
3. Cost the job: components per unit, labor time, suggested price.
4. Production runs with quality control — misaligned buttons get rejected and counted.
5. Deliver orders with an invoice (real or simulated).
6. Post-mortem: actual costs vs. estimate, reject rate, what a re-run would change.

ACTIVITY

Club & Event Branding — real orders, real deadlines, real unit economics. The reject-rate line item teaches quality control better than any lecture on craftsmanship.